

Math 199 (Math 314 Section HM1) Syllabus

Spring 2026

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Office Hours: Monday, 3pm-3:50pm
314 Davenport Hall

Website: [Math 199 \(Math 314 Section HM1\) Course Website - Spring 2026](#)

Meeting Time: Wednesday, 3pm-4:50pm

Meeting Location: 314 Davenport Hall

Welcome to Higher Mathematics! You've probably learned some mathematics before, but what's 'higher' about this class?

In short, most of the math you've learned so far has been from the perspective of 'what' is true, and using that to answer questions. In this class, we will shift our perspective to 'how' or 'why' things are true, and using that as a basis for finding out other things that are true (or false).

Since this shift can feel quite dramatic, the mathematical *content* of the course will often feel more elementary than things you've learned in the past few years. One difficulty you're likely to encounter will be in identifying why the question you are being asked isn't obvious. This is a key step in understanding the difference between 'what' and 'why', and it'll help you build your toolkit for addressing less obvious questions of this form in the future.

What is Math 199? What is a Merit discussion section?

As part of your Math 314 course, you will take part in a Math 314 discussion section that contributes to your Math 314 grade. Our *Merit* discussion section, while spiritually connected to 314, is a *separate course* that meets for 2 hours per week, under the name Math 199, and I am your instructor. Keep in mind that our Math 199 class is technically unrelated to your Math 314 responsibilities and grades. A Merit discussion section offers us time to explore the material you'll learn in Math 314 in a slightly different way. During this time, we will gain a deeper understanding of the material by thinking together and critically about interesting and/or difficult problems. Part of the philosophy of the merit program is that there is an element of learning that works best when you work in a small group to find your way towards the solution to a problem together. This will involve sharing your ideas, as well as listening to your group mates' ideas. The more paths towards a solution that you encounter, the better you'll know the landscape. In this spirit, I will often not give you the answers/solutions to the problems we will work on, but I *will* do my best to help guide you through your collective journey through mathematics.

Grade breakdown:

This is for your Math 199 grade. Your Math 115 grade is unrelated.

Attendance: 30%

Participation: 40%

Preparation: 30%

You will not be graded on the correctness of any mathematics that you do in Math 199.

Attendance: You will be graded on attendance. I will excuse one absence **no questions asked**. In addition, I will excuse two more absences for justifiable reasons that you discuss with me in advance (barring special circumstances). If you need to miss more days than these (e.g. due to prolonged illness/injury or family matter), you must speak to me, and we will find a solution that works for your case.

Lateness: 20 minutes late = absence and half credit for that day's participation score.
5 minutes late = half an absence.

Participation: Your raw score for this part of the grade will be based on your participation with (and submission of) the worksheets and other activities we do *in class*. I say "raw score" to indicate that you can raise this part of your grade by demonstrating your participation to me in other ways. On days that you are absent, you can make up participation points by turning in the assignment within one week of the date the assignment was done in class (excused = for full credit, unexcused = for half credit).

Preparation: Your raw score for this part of the grade will be based on the work you do *before class* to prepare for class. This will include short assignments I will ask you to do and hand in to help stimulate discussion about important topics in class. These assignments aren't typical "math homework" style assignments; they are meant to stimulate your preparation for class. As above, you can raise this grade above your raw score by demonstrating your preparation in other ways.

I hope you are all excited for an exciting semester of math and this great opportunity you have to engage with the material in a unique way. I am excited to get to know all of you and help you along as you progress through the course!